

Appendix B: Barratt Impulsiveness Scale (Revised)

Introduction: People differ in ways they act and think under various situations. Ernest Barratt developed the Barratt Impulsiveness Scale Test in 1995 to measure a person's level of impulsiveness.¹ This is a revised test incorporating my comments to help you identify and be aware of ways in which you react and think as an investor.

Directions: Read each statement and circle the appropriate number on the right side of this page. Do not spend too much time on any statement. Answer quickly and honestly. Refer to Table B.1.

Scores

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- 1 *Rarely/Never*
 - 2 *Occasionally*
 - 3 *Often*
 - 4 *Almost Always/Always*
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Scoring system: Before adding up your scores in each section, reverse the scores of reverse questions; for example, if your score on a reverse score question was 4, then reverse it to 1.

Then add up all your scores for the section.

Table B.1 Revised Barratt Impulsiveness Scale 1

Attentional Facet	Scores			
I.	1	2	3	4
1. I don't "pay attention."	1	2	3	4
2. I concentrate easily.	1	2	3	4
3. I "squirm" at plays or lectures.	1	2	3	4
4. I am a steady thinker.	1	2	3	4
5. I am restless at the theater or lectures.	1	2	3	4

(Continued)

Table B.1 (Continued)

II.	1	2	3	4
6. I have “racing” thoughts.	1	2	3	4

7. I change hobbies.

8. I often have extraneous thoughts when thinking.

Reverse score questions are: **2** and **4**

Your scores for Attentional Facet I: _____

Your scores for Attentional Facet II: _____

Comment: if your scores were low on both then you have a good attention span and cognitive stability, the qualities of nonimpulsivity.

Motor Facet

I.

9. I do things without thinking. 1 2 3 4

10. I make up my mind quickly. 1 2 3 4

11. I am happy-go-lucky. 1 2 3 4

12. I “act” on impulse. 1 2 3 4

13. I act on the spur of the moment. 1 2 3 4

14. I buy things on impulse. 1 2 3 4

15. I spend or charge more than I earn. 1 2 3 4

II. 1 2 3 4

16. I change jobs. 1 2 3 4

17. I change residences. 1 2 3 4

18. I can think only about one thing at a time. 1 2 3 4

19. I am future oriented. 1 2 3 4

Reverse score question is **19**

Your score for Motor Facet I: _____

Your score for Motor Facet II: _____

Comment: If you scored low on both, then you have good control of your motor actions and persevere in holding off on impulsive actions.

The answer to question 10 needs to be qualified. My assessment differs from the standard low score for nonimpulsivity. I accept a higher score for this question because I believe that an investor’s ability to make up his or her mind quickly with a quality decision is a positive factor. The ability to make a quick and yet not impulsive decision is the skill of an excellent instinctual investor. I see a mid to high score in this question as positive.

Planning Facet

I.

20. I plan tasks carefully.

21. I plan trips well ahead of time. 1 2 3 4

22. I am self-controlled. 1 2 3 4

23. I am a careful thinker. 1 2 3 4

24. I plan for job security. 1 2 3 4

25. I say things without thinking. 1 2 3 4

II. 1 2 3 4

26. I save regularly. 1 2 3 4

27. I like to think about complex problems. 1 2 3 4

28. I am easily bored when solving thought problems. 1 2 3 4

29. I am more interested in the present than in the future. 1 2 3 4

30. I like puzzles. 1 2 3 4

Reverse score questions are:

20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 26, 27, and 30

Table B.1 (Continued)

Your score for Planning Facet I: _____

Your score for Planning Facet II: _____

Comment: If you scored low on both, then you have good self-control in planning for your future and possess the cognitive ability for complexity, the reverse of an impulsive attitude.

With question 29, my assessment differs from the standard score. I accept a higher score for nonimpulsivity. While one's attitude of planning for the future is a sign of nonimpulsivity, for an investor, the ability to *focus on the present decision* and not be distracted by the prospects of future profits or an out-of-proportion fear of past or future losses is an asset. A higher score for those reasons is acceptable for this question and does not detract from being nonimpulsive.

Source: <http://www.impulsivity.org/pdf/BIS11English.pdf>, with author's revision incorporated in the scale.

Note

1. J. H. Patton, M. S. Stanford, and E. S. Barratt, "Factor structure of the Barratt Impulsiveness Scale," *Journal of Clinical Psychology* 51 (1995): 768–774.